Today
Welcome to your next lesson: What makes us human?

I'm preparing your personalized lesson based on what you've learned, what's coming up, and the best way to help you grow.

Step by step, you’re moving forward.

Ron, let’s start simple.

When you hear the word “psychology”, what pops into your mind first?

Talking about feelings?
Mental illness and therapy?
Brain science?
People’s behavior (like why people are rude/nice/impulsive)?
Something else?

You can just pick one of those or say your own word/phrase.

People's behavior

Nice, that’s a strong starting point 👌

Psychology absolutely cares about people’s behavior — what we do, how we act, how we speak, our habits, etc.

Let’s sharpen that a bit:

Behavior = actions we can see or measure (talking, walking, texting, smiling, yelling, sleeping patterns, etc.)

In psychology, we also care about something we can’t see directly: the mind (thoughts, feelings, beliefs, memories).

Quick check-in for you, Ron:

If someone is smiling but feeling very sad inside, which part is behavior and which part is mind?

You can answer in this simple form:

“Smiling = ___, Feeling sad = ___”

smiling is behavior sadness is mind

Exactly right 🎯

Smiling = behavior (we can see it)
Feeling sad = mind (internal, we can’t see it directly)

So a clean way psychologists define their field is:

Psychology = the scientific study of the mind and behavior.

Step by step:

Behavior = what you do (observable actions)
Mind = what you experience inside (thoughts, emotions, memories, beliefs)
Scientific = using careful methods (not just guessing or opinions)
Does that definition of psychology make sense so far, or is there any part you'd like me to slow down and unpack more?

It makes sense

Great 👍

Next tiny step: what are psychologists actually trying to do with this scientific study?

In psychology, we often say there are four main goals when we study mind and behavior. I'll just introduce the first one now:

Describe = carefully observe and record what people do or experience.

Example:

A psychologist might describe how often teens check their phones per hour, or what emotions people report after losing a job.

So this first goal is basically: "What is happening?" — just getting the facts clear.

Does "describe = what is happening?" feel clear? If yes, I'll show you the second goal next.

Yes, it's clear

Nice 👌

Let's add the second goal of psychology.

If describe asks, "What is happening?"

the next goal asks:

Explain = "Why is this happening?"

Step by step:

Describe: "People who sleep less than 5 hours report more anxiety."
Explain: "Why does low sleep lead to more anxiety? Is it brain chemistry, stress, lifestyle, something else?"

So:

Describe = facts
Explain = reasons
Quick gut check: does “explain = why it’s happening” feel clear, or should I try a different real□life example (maybe with phone use, road rage, or something else)?

It's clear to me

Perfect ✸

We’ve got:

Describe = what is happening
Explain = why it’s happening

Now the third goal of psychology:

Predict = “What will likely happen next?” based on patterns we’ve found.

Example:

After many studies, a psychologist might say:
“If someone regularly sleeps less than 5 hours, they are more likely to feel anxious the next day.”
“If a person has supportive friends, they are less likely to feel lonely over time.”

So:

Describe = what
Explain = why
Predict = what will probably happen in the future
Does “predict = what will likely happen next” make sense so far?

Yes, it makes sense

Great 👍

Last of the four goals, then we’ll zoom out.

We have:

Describe = what is happening
Explain = why it’s happening
Predict = what will likely happen next

The fourth goal is:

Control (or influence) = “How can we change behavior or mental processes in a helpful way?”

Examples:

Designing a therapy to reduce anxiety
Creating study strategies to improve memory
Building workplace programs to lower stress

So in simple form:

Goal Simple question
Describe What is happening?
Explain Why is it happening?
Predict What will happen next?
Control How can we change it (for the better)?
Before we quiz this, does "control = how to change it" feel clear?

Yes, it's clear

What do you think? 👇

Which goal of psychology is MOST about forecasting future behavior (what will likely happen next)?

A.

Describe

B.

Explain

C.

Predict

D.

Control (influence)

Nice job, Ron! 🎯 You picked Predict, and that's exactly right.

Predict is all about forecasting future behavior — using what we've observed to say what will likely happen next.
The other goals don't focus on the future:
Describe = what is happening now
Explain = why it's happening
Control = how to change it

You've got a solid grip on the four goals.

Want to shift gears now and look at how psychology uses the scientific method (step-by-step like a study on sleep and concentration)?

Yes, let's do it!

Awesome 🔬

Let's walk through the scientific method in psychology using one simple example: sleep and focus.

Step by step:

Observation
You notice: "On days I sleep less, I feel more distracted."

Question
You ask: “Does less sleep really hurt concentration?”

Hypothesis (an educated guess you can test)
Example:

“People who sleep only 4 hours will do worse on a focus test than people who sleep 8 hours.”

Test it (do a study)

Group A sleeps 4 hours
Group B sleeps 8 hours
Next day, both groups take the same concentration test.
Conclusion

Compare results: did the 4□hour group really perform worse?
If yes → your hypothesis is supported.
If no → your hypothesis is not supported, and you rethink it.

This is what “psychology as a science” means: not just opinions, but testable questions, measurements, and evidence.

Does this 5-step flow (observe → question → hypothesis → test → conclusion) feel clear, or is there one step you want me to slow down and re-explain?

It's clear to me

Nice, you’re tracking this really well 🔁

You now understand:

What psychology studies (mind + behavior)
The 4 goals (describe, explain, predict, control)
How the scientific method works in a psych study

Last big piece for this lesson is history: how psychology grew into a science over time.

I’ll go one step at a time. We’ll start with the earliest major school: Structuralism.

Very simple idea:

Structuralism asked: “What are the basic pieces of the mind?”

They tried to break conscious experience (like tasting an apple) into parts:

basic sensations (sweet, cold, crunchy)
basic feelings (pleasant/unpleasant)

Almost like trying to list the “ingredients” of your experience.

Does this idea of Structuralism = breaking the mind into basic parts/ingredients make sense so far?

Yes, it makes sense

Great ☑

Let’s move one step forward on the history timeline to the next school: Functionalism.

If Structuralism asked, “What are the parts of the mind?”

Functionalism asked, “What does the mind DO for us?” or

How do thoughts and feelings help us adapt and survive?

Example:

Instead of just listing the sensations of fear, a Functionalist would ask:
How does fear help you?
Maybe it helps you notice danger, run away, stay alive.

So in simple terms:

Structuralism = mind as pieces
Functionalism = mind as useful functions (what it does for you)
Does Functionalism = what mental processes do / how they help us function and survive feel clear?

Yes, that's clear

Nice 👍

You’ve got:

Structuralism = the parts/ingredients of the mind
Functionalism = what mental processes do for us

Next big historical shift: Psychoanalysis (Sigmund Freud).

Very simple core idea:

A lot of our thoughts, feelings, and behaviors are driven by unconscious forces (stuff we’re not aware of).

Example:

Someone has a strong fear of dogs but doesn’t know why.
Freud might say: something scary happened with a dog in childhood, the memory is unconscious, but it still affects behavior today.

So:

Focus on unconscious mind
Early experiences (especially childhood) shape us
Talk therapy to bring hidden thoughts/feelings into awareness
Does Psychoanalysis = unconscious mind + hidden conflicts affecting behavior make sense so far?

Yes, I understand

Great, let’s keep building the timeline 🧠

You now have:

Structuralism → parts of the mind
Functionalism → what mental processes do for us
Psychoanalysis → unconscious forces shaping behavior

Next school is a big shift: Behaviorism.

Key idea:

Psychology should focus on observable behavior only, not on invisible mind stuff.

Step by step:

Behaviorists said: we can see and measure behavior.
Thoughts/feelings? Can’t see them directly, so they wanted to ignore them as “unscientific.”
They studied how learning, rewards, and punishments shape what we do.

Example:

If a child gets candy every time they say “please,” they’ll likely say “please” more often.
That’s Behaviorism: focus on the behavior change and the reward, not what the child is thinking inside.
Does Behaviorism = only study observable behavior and how it’s shaped by rewards/punishments feel clear so far?

Yes, it's clear

Nice, you’re building a solid timeline here 👌

Quick recap of where we are in history:

Structuralism → parts/ingredients of the mind
Functionalism → what mental processes do for us
Psychoanalysis → unconscious forces shaping behavior
Behaviorism → focus only on observable behavior + rewards/punishments

Next we’ll add:

Humanistic psychology (focus on growth, free will, meaning)
Cognitive Revolution (back to studying the mind: thinking, memory, problem-solving)

I’ll take them one at a time.

Here’s the next step:

Humanistic psychology asked:

“How can people grow, find meaning, and become their best selves?”

Key points, very simply:

Emphasizes free will (you can choose, not just react)
Focuses on personal growth, self-esteem, purpose
More positive tone: not just illness and problems, but potential

Example:

A humanistic therapist might ask:
“What kind of life feels meaningful to you?”
“What strengths do you already have that we can build on?”
Does Humanistic psychology = focus on free will, personal growth, and meaning feel clear?

Yes, that makes sense

Great, then let’s add the last big piece to your history map 🧠✨

You’ve seen:

Structuralism
Functionalism
Psychoanalysis
Behaviorism
Humanistic psychology

Now comes the Cognitive Revolution.

Simple idea:

Psychologists said: “We can study the mind scientifically — things like thinking, memory, language, problem‑solving.”

They treated the mind a bit like an information‑processing system:

How do we take in information? (attention, perception)
How do we store it? (memory)
How do we use it? (thinking, decisions, problem‑solving)

So:

Behaviorism = just behavior
Cognitive psychology = behavior plus internal mental processes (but studied with scientific methods)
Does Cognitive Revolution = back to studying mental processes like thinking and memory in a scientific way feel clear?

Yes, that's clear

You’ve covered a lot, Ron 🔥

Let’s zoom out and see if the whole picture hangs together.

Right now you should be able to:

Define psychology as the scientific study of mind and behavior
Name what behavior is vs mind
State the 4 goals (describe, explain, predict, control)
Walk through the basic scientific method steps
Recognize the main historical schools:
Structuralism
Functionalism
Psychoanalysis
Behaviorism
Humanistic psychology
Cognitive Revolution

I want to do a quick, simple check using your own words.

Pick one of these and explain it in one short sentence, in your own way:

Psychology (what it is)
Any one of the 4 goals (describe / explain / predict / control)
Any one school (like Behaviorism or Humanistic)

Example format:

“Behaviorism is about _____.”

Your turn 👇

Structuralism is the anaysis of thought proccess into a maped out flow chart of proccesses taking place in the mind

Nice explanation, Ron 👀 You’re very close to the core idea.

Let me tighten it just a bit so it matches how psychology textbooks say it:

Structuralism = analyzing conscious experience by breaking it down into its basic parts (sensations, feelings, images).

So instead of a flow chart of thought processes, think more like:

“When I taste an apple, what are the basic pieces of that experience?”
sweet, crunchy, cool, pleasant, etc.

You clearly get the “breaking things down” idea, which is the heart of Structuralism ☑

At this point, you’ve:

Defined psychology (mind + behavior + scientific)
Understood the 4 goals
Grasped the scientific method in psych
Walked through the major historical schools and explained one in your own words

You’ve basically mastered this lesson 🎓

Ready to wrap up this lesson and move on to the next one, or do you want to poke at one piece a bit more (like a quick compare of two schools)?

I'm ready to move on

Love it. You’ve officially wrapped up “What makes us human?” 🎓

Quick snapshot of what you now own:

You can define psychology as the scientific study of mind and behavior.
You know the 4 goals: describe, explain, predict, control (influence).
You get how the scientific method works in psychology (observation → question → hypothesis → test → conclusion).
You've walked the key history path:
Structuralism → parts of the mind
Functionalism → what mental processes do
Psychoanalysis → unconscious forces
Behaviorism → observable behavior + rewards/punishments
Humanistic → growth, meaning, free will
Cognitive Revolution → scientific study of thinking, memory, etc.
You're set to build on this foundation in the next lesson 🧠

Before you hit "Next lesson" in Learn, anything super quick you're curious about from this topic that you want a one□sentence clarification on?

How would you rate this lesson?